

Characters and Factions of Aetheln

Document Status

This is the canonical character and faction summary. It updates the earlier Champions of the First Cycle artifact for the two-faction, mandatory open-world-PvP direction.

Faction names are working names. Character loyalties describe their current position and may change through the story.

Playable anatomy, visual identity, culture, and presentation contracts are defined in Playable Peoples.

Faction Conflict

Dawn Concordat - Working Name

The Dawn Concordat believes scarce Ember-light must be regulated and shared under a common law. Its members fear that independent stockpiles will create another Duskbreak.

Its virtues are discipline, collective defense, and continuity. Its dangers are authoritarian control, procedural cruelty, and the belief that individual lives can be sacrificed for stability.

Gameplay identity:

- Wards, banners, formation support, and defensive siege tools.
- Holding ground and protecting shared objectives.
- Regulated travel and resource logistics.
- Doctrine choices that reward coordination and prepared defense.

Unbound Flame - Working Name

The Unbound Flame believes settlements and individuals who recover Embers should decide how to use them. Its members view the Concord's monopoly as a different form of slow extinction.

Its virtues are autonomy, adaptability, mercy, and local responsibility. Its dangers are fragmentation, hoarding, opportunism, and extremists who confuse freedom with entitlement.

Gameplay identity:

- Mobility, disruption, infiltration, and field improvisation.
- Breaking formations and stealing contested resources.
- Flexible travel and independent supply.
- Doctrine choices that reward timing, adaptation, and coordinated disruption.

The Concord

The Concord is the old legal and religious structure governing Ember use. It is not identical to the Dawn Concordat, although the Dawn Concordat broadly supports it. The Concord attempts to mediate the conflict while also protecting its authority.

The Ashen Choir

The Ashen Choir is hostile to both player factions. It is the surviving remnant of the Lucent Choir and intends to complete the ritual that cracked the Waking Star.

The Ashen Choir must not become a playable faction in the initial design.

The Emberbound Table

The Emberbound Table contains champions whose loyalties divide the world. They are connected by the Duskbreak, Concord law, and Choirmaster Sevrin Vale.

Kaelen Dross - The Last Gate

- **People:** Aurin
- **Class:** Bulwark
- **Current alignment:** Dawn Concordat
- **Combat lesson:** block, flank, feint, and punish

Kaelen served as the Concord's executioner. His final commission was his own brother, Maren, who murdered pilgrims for a dying Ember. Kaelen performed the death rite himself and forged his tower shield from the door of their family home.

Kaelen believes law prevented greater bloodshed, but Corvath's preservation of Maren forces him to live beside the possibility that duty did not end his brother's suffering.

Conflict:

- Enforces the system Nhalen considers unjust.
- Respects Vothram despite their opposing politics.
- Trained Serra and recognizes that the Concord is consuming her family.
- Could become either the Dawn Concordat's unbreakable defender or the person who finally refuses an order.

Serra Vale - The Ashen Heir

- **People:** Aurin
- **Class:** Skeinblade
- **Current alignment:** undecided at the beginning
- **Combat lesson:** attack commitment, dodge timing, and recovery punishment

Serra is the last known descendant of Sevrin Vale, the Choirmaster who cracked the Star. Rather than execute the Vale family, the Concord condemned every generation to publicly earn back a name that can never be cleared.

The Ashen Choir has begun contacting her. Her story is not a simple corruption arc: both factions want to turn her inherited guilt into a political weapon.

Conflict:

- Dawn leaders demand proof of loyalty that can never be complete.
- Unbound leaders offer freedom but may want her name more than her trust.
- Aldrec believes she is already compromised.
- Her faction decision is a major story pivot and remains intentionally open.

Nhalen - The Gutterlight

- **People:** Vesh
- **Class:** Skeinblade
- **Current alignment:** Unbound Flame
- **Combat lesson:** reads, timing, and skill over raw attunement

Nhalen killed an Ashen Choir agent to save a captive child. No sanctioned arbiter was present, so the Concord applied its law without considering motive. His attunement was severed and he was permanently barred from holding an Ember.

Nhalen fights without supernatural advantage and remains one of the finest combat instructors alive.

Conflict:

- Aldrec confirmed the killing was justified and concealed that truth.
- Kaelen represents the enforcement that destroyed Nhalen's future.
- Nhalen opposes the Concord but rejects indiscriminate revenge.
- He teaches players that equipment and light create options, not automatic victory.

Saeril - Nine-Dreams

- **People:** Vesh
- **Class:** Embercaller
- **Current alignment:** public Dawn Concordat figurehead
- **Combat lesson:** gap closing, interruption, and zone pressure

Saeril is the greatest living Ember champion. Each Ember she integrated consumed a memory. She records her lost identity in a journal because she no longer remembers why she began climbing.

Her ninth recurring dream identifies a future betrayal within the Emberbound Table. She has not revealed the traitor or whether the act is truly a betrayal.

Conflict:

- The Dawn Concordat uses her as proof that controlled ascension works.
- The Unbound Flame sees her as proof that the system consumes its champions.
- Matron Halveth manages her decline.
- Her eventual decision can change the perceived legitimacy of the faction war.

Aldrec Fane - The Pyrelaw

- **People:** Aurin
- **Class:** Embercaller
- **Current alignment:** Dawn Concordat hardliner
- **Combat lesson:** movement, pressure zones, and low-health danger

Aldrec is a Concord inquisitor whose family died in an Ashen Choir atrocity. His commitment to destroying the Choir is sincere.

He also verified that Nhalen acted to save a child and allowed the punishment to stand because he believed the law's example mattered more than one innocent life.

Conflict:

- Builds a case against Serra from evidence that is real but incomplete.
- Audits Vothram's vault while Vothram falsifies its records.
- Treats Unbound autonomy as the first stage of another catastrophe.
- Embodies the danger of correct facts serving an inhuman conclusion.

Corvath - The Still

- **People:** Kell
- **Class:** Lumen
- **Current alignment:** Unbound Flame sympathizer
- **Combat lesson:** line of sight, healing angles, and area control

Corvath crystallized from the glassed earth during the Duskbreak and remembers the catastrophe from inside its light. He remains a unique living-glass Kell: his complete material state is not ordinary Kell biology or an available player appearance.

He preserves people at the instant before death as conscious, painless living glass. Among them is Maren Dross. Corvath considers this mercy; others consider it an endless refusal to let the dead pass.

Conflict:

- Rejects Concord ownership of memory and death.
- Opens the sealed Hollow Choirhouse for the player.
- Opposes Halveth over whether remembrance belongs in a ledger or a living witness.
- His preservation practice divides even his Unbound allies.

Vothram - The Forgedoor

- **People:** Kell
- **Class:** Bulwark
- **Current alignment:** covert Unbound Flame supporter
- **Combat lesson:** guard pressure, stamina breaking, and heavy commitment

Vothram forged the instruments Sevrin used to crack the Star. He did not know their purpose, but ignorance did not save the cities they destroyed.

He now guards the Concord's Ember vault. Secretly, he preserves memory-Embers that the law requires him to surrender and allow to expire.

Conflict:

- His archive can preserve history or become a private hoard.
- The Ashen Choir knows the vault's true inventory.
- Aldrec is closing in on the falsified records.
- Kaelen is his rival, friend, and political opposite.

Matron Halveth - The Ledger

- **People:** Aurin
- **Class:** Lumen
- **Current alignment:** Dawn Concordat authority
- **Combat lesson:** patience, denial, and cooldown discipline

Halveth controls attunement rites. She once refused an unready village champion. Without an eligible claimant, the village could not replace its dying Ember-well, and hundreds died.

She records every person affected by her decisions but continues to believe that consistent law is the only barrier against collapse.

Conflict:

- Represents lawful harm rather than personal malice.
- Controls access to power the Unbound Flame wants decentralized.
- Manages Saeril's loss of memory.
- Authorized Kaelen's commission against Maren.

Primary Antagonist

Choirmaster Sevrin Vale

- **Faction:** Ashen Choir
- **Role:** initial dungeon antagonist and living origin of the faction crisis

Sevrin led the attempt to make the golden age eternal. The ritual cracked the Waking Star and left him sustained by the stolen light.

He believes the failure came from incomplete execution rather than a false premise. Both player factions oppose him, but each uses his crime to justify a different future for Ember control.

Relationship Threads

Law and Autonomy

Halveth authorizes, Kaelen enforces, Aldrec investigates, and Nhalen bears the punishment. Their conflict gives the faction war a human cost.

Blood of the Duskbreak

Sevrin designed the ritual, Vothram forged its instruments, Corvath was created by its destruction, Serra inherited its blame, and Aldrec hunts its survivors.

Memory and Ownership

Saeril loses memories to power, Vothram steals memories to preserve them, Corvath keeps memory alive in glass, and Halveth records the dead in law. The faction conflict asks whether memory can ever be owned for the common good.

Future Fractures

- Saeril's ninth dream points to a traitor.
- Serra must choose whether either faction deserves her loyalty.
- Kaelen may refuse an order involving Maren.
- Aldrec's concealment of Nhalen's innocence can damage the Dawn Concordat.
- Vothram's archive can strengthen the Unbound cause or expose its hypocrisy.

Character Creation Rules

- Aurin, Kell, Vesh, and future playable races support male and female characters.
- Sex, body preset, and race do not change combat statistics or hitboxes.
- Every playable race may use every supported class.
- Every playable race may join either player faction.
- Character appearance and voice are independent from class, faction, Skein, equipment, and progression data.
- Aurin, Kell, and Vesh use the race-specific appearance and shared combat contracts defined in Playable Peoples.

Faction selection enters the playable delivery in 2.0. Before that stage, persisted characters use `Faction = Unassigned` and have no Doctrine. The approved one-time selection then assigns the protected starting territory, faction story, and Doctrine; any later faction-change policy remains open.